Throughout this time, the United States may have had reason to look the other way: some in Washington believed that Pakistan–China nuclear cooperation would help balance against the Soviet Union. Furthermore, the US legislation known as the Pressler Amendment, while widely heralded in India as a punitive measure against Pakistan, was in fact nothing of the sort. Rather, it enabled the United States to keep funnelling military and economic aid to Pakistan until 1990. By that time, Pakistan's nuclear development was advanced enough that the US president had no choice but to determine that Pakistan was in possession of a nuclear device and cut off military assistance. Not coincidentally, by then, Pakistan's support for the United States' assistance to the *mujahideen* in Afghanistan was no longer needed. [30]

Thus, the progress that Pakistan made in acquiring a nuclear weapon capability throughout the 1970s and 1980s became another impetus for India to pursue a nuclear deterrent. From 1974 onwards, Indian intelligence closely monitored Pakistan's nuclear programme. In April 1979, just as the United States cut off economic and military aid to Pakistan on non-proliferation grounds for the first time, India's Joint Intelligence Committee concluded that Pakistan's nuclear programme had made considerable headway. India's nuclear weapon initiative was therefore resumed, although not without further political, technical, and procedural delays. By 1983, Indira Gandhi authorized a further nuclear test, but swiftly reversed her decision. In 1985, Rajiv Gandhi authorized a task force—which included Army Vice Chief K. Sundarji and A.P.J. Abdul Kalam, among other military and scientific figures—to assess the costs of a nuclear deterrent. It concluded that a 'balanced minimum deterrent' with warheads in the 'low three digits' would cost less than 10 per cent of India's defence budget over ten years. [31] DRDO continued working steadily on weaponization and delivery systems throughout the mid- and late-1980s, despite Rajiv Gandhi internationally proposing an Action Plan for achieving nuclear disarmament in a timebound manner. India's first short-range Prithvi missile test took place in 1988, and a year later Pakistan tested its Hatf-I missile. But India